

The Hat Trick MAN

Riding his clean image and report card, Naveen Patnaik makes history by winning a clear mandate for the BJD and a third successive term as chief minister for himself

| By Farzand Ahmed |

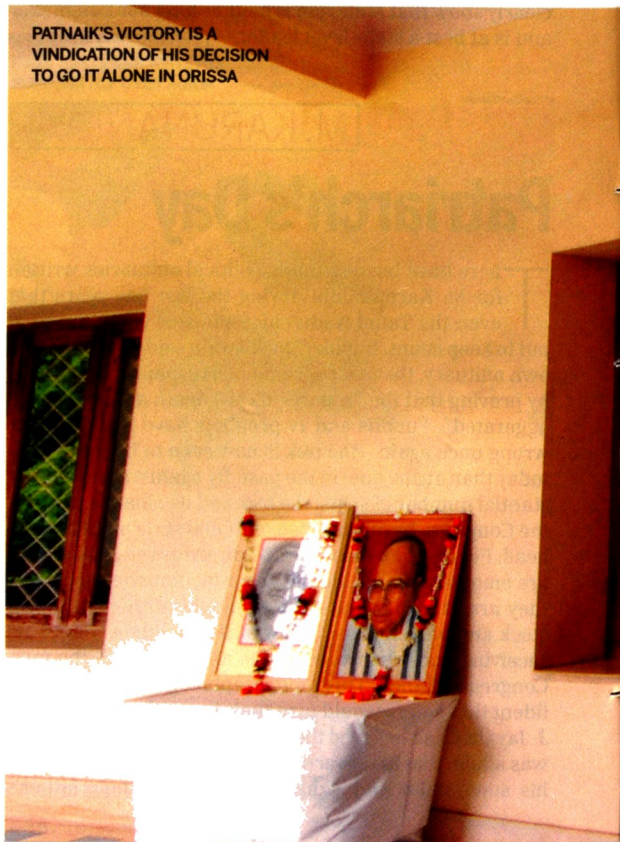
Naveen Patnaik is by nature a loner in politics. Also, one who takes his secular credentials and his image as a man of the people very seriously. So, it was not entirely a surprise when he snapped his electoral alliance with the BJP just before the elections, ostensibly over the communal bloodshed in Kandhamal. It was a calculated risk to go it alone. After all he had been chief minister for two terms; many development and industrial projects had been stalled and the anti-incumbency factor was hanging over his head. It was a gamble that has paid off in spades. He has just registered a hat trick as chief minister and in the process created some sort of history in Orissa by sweeping the assembly and Lok Sabha polls. Clearly, 'Naveen babu' has struck a chord with the people of Orissa with his low-key style, clean, secular image and genuine concern for the state's progress.

In fact, what seems to have helped him the most was the negative campaign launched by his former alliance partner, the BJP, which based its campaign on playing up Patnaik's "betrayal". The result—an overwhelming vote in favour of his Biju Janata Dal (BJD) which even exceeded his own expectations. "I have been humbled by the people," he said as the results came in. Buoyed by the numbers, he promised his government would take the state into an era of peace, prosperity and communal harmony and declared he would work harder "to fulfil the promises I made to the people".

It was a remarkable victory and Patnaik alone deserves credit since he waged a relentless campaign all by himself in the blazing heat as he criss-crossed the entire

state repeatedly. Speaking in his characteristically soft voice, he demolished the Congress' image by referring to it as "goonda raj, contractor raj" and also asked the electorate to give "a fitting reply to the saffron party (BJP) for its attempt to communalise the state politics". He also effectively convinced voters that his government's achievements had been geared to improve their lives. A confused and demoralised BJP on the other hand had nothing new to offer despite the campaign blitzkrieg which saw a galaxy of Central leaders descend on Orissa, all harping on the 'betrayal' theme which turned off the common Oriya voter. "People have punished the BJP for its negative and communal politics," said BJD Secretary-

PATNAIK'S VICTORY IS A
VINDICATION OF HIS DECISION
TO GO IT ALONE IN ORISSA



Orissa

Total Seats 147

PARTY	SEATS 2009	SEATS 2004	Vote Share%*
BJD	103	68	29.4
CONG	26	38	34.8
BJP	6	32	17.1
OTHERS	10	9	18.7

Two results for 2009 are awaited